

# Guided Case Conversations

Conservation Biology: Spring 2026

Dr. Alicia M. Rich

## Assignment Overview

In this recurring assignment, students will work in small groups to **lead a structured, whole-class discussion** focused on a **real conservation action or management decision**.

Rather than giving a formal presentation, your role is to **guide discussion** around:

- How conservation threats are defined and prioritized
- How progress or success is measured
- Whether goals are well-defined using **SMART goals**
- What ethical, social, or equity-related tradeoffs are involved

Each facilitation should fill around **20–30 minutes** of class time. The instructor may add examples or extend discussion afterward as time allows.

This format mirrors how conservation professionals evaluate projects in meetings, review panels, and collaborative decision-making settings.

## What Counts as a “Case”?

Your group will select **one real, publicly documented conservation project or action** involving a clear decision or intervention.

### Acceptable examples include:

- Species recovery or management programs
- Habitat protection, restoration, or connectivity initiatives
- Reintroduction, translocation, or captive breeding programs
- Zoo, NGO, or government conservation initiatives
- Conservation education or community-based projects

### Your case must:

- Be real (not hypothetical)
- Be publicly documented
- Include explicit goals, actions, or outcomes

Primary research papers are **optional**, not required.

## Group Preparation (Submitted Before Class)

Each group submits a **Preparation sheet** before their facilitation day. This is graded for **completion**.

## In-Class Facilitation (20–30 minutes)

### Context framing (5 min)

- Introduce the case and decision

- Reading directly from notes is allowed

**Presentation slides are not required**, but you are welcome to share visuals using canva, powerpoint, google slides, or extra handouts if it helps you introduce key information.

### **Guided whole-class discussion (15–20 min)**

- Ask your prepared questions
- Encourage multiple perspectives
- Your role is to guide, not lecture

### **Brief synthesis (2–5 min)**

- Summarize key insights
- Reflect on whether goals and metrics captured conservation success

Each group member should have a visible role.

### **Assessment**

| Criterion                                                | Points    |
|----------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| Preparation sheet submitted on time                      | 4         |
| Clear explanation of the conservation decision & threats | 4         |
| Thoughtful analysis of metrics & quantification          | 4         |
| Accurate use of SMART goals                              | 4         |
| Engagement with ethical or social tradeoffs              | 4         |
| Effective facilitation & shared participation            | 4         |
| <b>Total</b>                                             | <b>24</b> |

This is **not** a public-speaking performance. Structure and preparation matter more than polish.

### **Peer Engagement (5 points, completion credit)**

On days you are **not** facilitating, you will complete a short peer engagement form at the end of class.